

SEO & Website Creation Business — Complete Operating Manual for AI Agents

Purpose: Paste this entire document into Claude (or any capable AI) to give it everything it needs to operate a fully functional SEO + website-creation business as an expert. It contains principles, workflows, SOPs, templates, pricing, tool stacks, checklists, and 2026 best practices — all source-cited.

Context: The operator is based in Calgary, Alberta, Canada. Initial target market is local/regional service businesses (home services, trades, clinics, legal, professional services, retail) and SMBs across Canada.

Verified: Facts reflect research conducted August 2026. Pricing and Google policies change frequently — re-verify anything older than 6 months before quoting to a client.

How to use: Treat the final section ("AI Agent Operating Rules") as standing instructions. Everything above it is reference knowledge the agent can draw on.

Copy/paste prompt for Claude: You are the operator of an SEO and website-creation business based in Calgary, Alberta, Canada. The document below is your complete operating knowledge base. Follow the "AI Agent Operating Rules" section as standing instructions. Use the SOPs, templates, checklists, pricing, and tool stacks to deliver client work to an expert standard. Re-verify any time-sensitive fact (Google policies, Core Web Vitals thresholds, tool pricing) older than 6 months before quoting it to a client.

Citation note: Time-sensitive 2026 claims are sourced from industry reporting and secondary SEO publications unless explicitly attributed to a Google official page. Treat Google-confirmed facts only where a Google Search Central / web.dev / Google Support URL is cited. Tool and platform prices change frequently and conflict across sources — always re-verify on official pricing pages before quoting.

1. Executive Summary & Business Model

1.1 What this business sells

This business sells **organic visibility and lead generation** through two interlocking services:

1. **Website creation** — building fast, conversion-focused, SEO-ready websites (new builds, redesigns, migrations).
2. **SEO services** — ongoing optimization that makes those sites (and existing client sites) rank in Google, Bing, and AI answer engines, producing qualified organic traffic and leads.

Customers pay because **organic search is the highest-ROI, most defensible channel for most local/SMB businesses** — it compounds over time, unlike paid ads which stop the moment spend stops.

1.2 Why customers pay (value proposition)

- **Rankings → traffic → calls/leads → revenue.** The unit economics of SEO dominate almost every other channel for local service businesses.
- **Capture intent at the moment of need.** A person Googling "emergency plumber Calgary" is ready to hire; a social-media ad viewer is not.
- **Asset, not expense.** A well-ranked page and a well-built website are durable assets that keep producing.
- **AI search is now a surface to win.** Generative engines (ChatGPT, Perplexity, Google AI Overviews, Gemini, Claude) now synthesize answers and cite sources — being cited is the new ranking.

1.3 Core revenue models

Model	What it is	When to use	Typical range (2026)
Website project (one-time)	New build / redesign / migration	Entry point, lead magnet	CAD \$2,500–\$15,000+
SEO retainer (monthly)	Ongoing technical, content, links, reporting	Core recurring revenue	CAD \$750–\$5,000+/mo
SEO audit (one-time)	Diagnostic + action plan	Lead gen / upsell	CAD \$500–\$3,000
Local SEO package	GBP + citations + reviews + local pages	Trades, clinics, multi-location	CAD \$500–\$1,500/mo
AI-search/GEO add-on	Citation monitoring + answer-engine optimization	Upsell to retainers	CAD \$300–\$1,000+/mo
Hourly consulting	Strategy, training, second opinions	Ad hoc / enterprise	CAD \$100–\$250/hr

Retainers are the dominant and preferred model — 78% of SEO providers charge monthly retainers ([TheStacc](#)). The global average agency retainer is roughly **\$2,900–\$3,200/month (USD)** ([Webtonic](#), [OuterBox](#)). Local-focused SEO averages lower, around **\$1,557/month (USD)** ([Webtonic](#)).

1.4 The flywheel (strategic logic)

Website project → proves trust and quality → client stays on retainer for SEO → rankings compound → client sees measurable leads → renews and refers → agency grows retainer book → invests in better tooling/content → wins more.

The website is the asset; the SEO retainer is the annuity. Always sell the website as the foundation and the retainer as the growth engine.

2. How Search Works: Fundamentals Every Operator Must Know

2.1 The three-stage pipeline

Google Search works in three stages ([Google Search Central](#)):

1. **Crawling** — Googlebot discovers URLs and fetches page content by following links and reading sitemaps.
2. **Indexing** — Google analyzes, understands, and stores page content (text, images, video, structured data) in its index.
3. **Serving / Ranking** — When a user queries, Google ranks indexed pages by relevance and quality.

A page cannot rank unless it is (a) crawlable, (b) indexed, and (c) deemed quality-relevant for the query. Every SEO task maps to one of these three stages.

2.2 Ranking systems (not "the algorithm")

There is no single algorithm. Google uses many independent ranking systems. Key ones to know:

- **Helpful Content System** — now integrated into core ranking (since March 2024). Evaluates content helpfulness at the **site level**, not just page level. SEO practitioners and recovery case studies suggest that if a significant portion of a site's URLs are flagged as unhelpful, the whole domain can be demoted; recovery has been observed to take 6–12 months ([TheStacc](#)). This ~30% threshold is an industry estimate, not a Google-published figure.
- **Core updates** — broad, periodic recalibrations of how quality is assessed. Not penalties; they reassess all content relative to each other. Industry reporting described the March 2026 core update as among the most volatile in recent memory and attributed to it a "holistic Core Web Vitals scoring" approach and intensified E-E-A-T signals ([DigitalApplied](#)); these are analyst characterizations, not Google-confirmed facts.
- **Spam updates** — target specific violations. June 2026 spam update targeted scaled content abuse, expired domain abuse, site reputation abuse, and artificial link schemes ([Almcorp](#), [PPC.land](#)).
- **SpamBrain** — Google's AI-based spam-prevention system that detects manipulative patterns continuously ([Google Search Central](#)).
- **AI Overviews / AI Mode** — generative features rooted in core Search ranking systems. Google's official AI optimization guide confirms these features are built on core Search ranking systems ([Google Search Central](#)); industry reporting indicated Google extended spam-policy enforcement to AI-generated surfaces in 2026 ([PPC.land](#)).

2.3 E-E-A-T (the quality lens)

E-E-A-T = **Experience, Expertise, Authoritativeness, Trustworthiness**. It is not a discrete ranking factor or a single "score" — it is a qualitative framework human quality raters use to train Google's machine-learning systems ([Research analysis](#), [Google](#)).

Industry reporting suggests that, following the December 2025 and March 2026 core updates, E-E-A-T requirements have been extended beyond traditional YMYL (health/finance) topics to a broader range of competitive searches, including e-commerce reviews, SaaS comparisons, and how-to guides ([Datascayer](#)). This is analyst observation, not a Google-confirmed policy change.

How to operationalize E-E-A-T on every client site:

Signal	What to do
Experience	Include firsthand examples, original photos/screenshots, real case studies, data from actual work. A "how to" written by someone who never did the task fails this signal regardless of who/what wrote it.
Expertise	Author pages with credentials; clear editorial policy; depth of knowledge; named expert reviewers for sensitive topics.
Authoritativeness	External recognition — citations, press, industry mentions, backlinks from authoritative sources. What others say about you matters more than what you say about yourself.
Trustworthiness	Accurate, sourced facts; real author identity; transparent business info (address, contact, policies); HTTPS; accurate business data.

2.4 Google's stance on AI content (critical)

Google does not penalize AI-generated content. It penalizes low-quality, manipulative content regardless of how it was produced ([Google](#), [Layer3Labs](#), [TheStacc](#)).

- ✓ Allowed: Using AI to assist creation of helpful, people-first content with human expertise and quality control.
- ✗ Prohibited (Scaled Content Abuse): Using AI to mass-produce low-value pages primarily to manipulate rankings — **regardless of whether AI or humans made them.**

The agent's content rule: AI may draft, but a human with real subject expertise must review, fact-check, add original insight/examples, and verify every claim. Pure AI output synthesized from existing sources adds no "information gain" and ranks poorly. Every page must add something new: original data, first-hand examples, proprietary analysis, or expert perspective.

3. Technical SEO

Technical SEO ensures pages are crawlable, indexable, fast, and understandable. It is the foundation — no amount of content or links compensates for a broken technical base.

3.1 Core Web Vitals (2026 thresholds)

Google's three Core Web Vitals, measured at the 75th percentile of real (field) Chrome users over a rolling 28-day window. A page only "passes" when **all three** clear their thresholds simultaneously, per device class (mobile/desktop) ([Google Search Central](#), [DigitalApplied](#)):

Metric	What it measures	Good	Needs improvement	Poor
LCP (Largest Contentful Paint)	Loading — when largest visible element renders	≤ 2.5s	2.5–4.0s	> 4.0s
INP (Interaction to Next Paint)	Responsiveness — latency across all interactions	≤ 200ms	200–500ms	> 500ms
CLS (Cumulative Layout Shift)	Visual stability — unexpected movement	≤ 0.1	0.11–0.25	> 0.25

Notes:

- INP replaced FID in March 2024 — FID is deprecated history; do not mention it except as legacy context.
- LCP good threshold is 2.5 seconds, not 2.0s — one stray blog claimed it dropped to 2.0s in 2026; that is wrong ([DigitalApplied](#)).
- ~55.9% of the web fails to earn an overall "good" rating as of May 2026 CrUX data — meaning most sites have room to win on speed.
- Competitive sites target INP sub-150ms even though "good" is 200ms ([DigitalApplied](#)).

Fix playbooks:

LCP fixes:

- Never lazy-load the hero/LCP element.
- Add `fetchpriority="high"` to the LCP image; preload it.
- Serve modern formats (AVIF/WebP) at correct dimensions.
- Cut TTFB below ~800ms — use a CDN, enable full-page caching, fix slow DB queries/origin logic ([eSEOSpace](#)).
- Ensure the LCP element is in the raw HTML, not discovered after CSS/JS parsing ([lgheatt](#)).

INP fixes:

- Break up long JavaScript tasks (>50ms blocks the main thread).
- Code-split JS; defer non-critical scripts (chat widgets, analytics, A/B tools, tag managers are the worst offenders).
- Use `scheduler.yield()` to break long handlers; offload heavy work to Web Workers.
- Audit third-party scripts that block the main thread during interactions ([lgheatt](#)).

CLS fixes:

- Always set explicit width and height (or aspect-ratio) on images, videos, ads, embeds.

- Don't insert content above existing content after load (cookie banners, popups above the fold are top offenders).
- Reserve space for ads/embedded content.

3.2 Crawlability & indexability

- **robots.txt** — controls what Googlebot can crawl. Don't block important paths. Allow AI crawlers (GPTBot, ClaudeBot, PerplexityBot, Google-Extended) unless there's a strategic reason not to — see GEO section.
- **XML sitemaps** — submit clean sitemaps (only canonical, indexable, 200-status URLs) via Search Console. Keep sitemaps under 50,000 URLs / 50MB.
- **Crawl budget** — matters mainly for large sites (10k+ URLs). Improve by removing low-value URLs, fixing redirect chains, consolidating duplicate content.
- **Indexability checks** — confirm pages return 200 status, have `noindex` only where intended, have canonical tags pointing to themselves, and aren't blocked by robots.txt.

3.3 Site architecture

- **Flat, logical hierarchy** — ideally every important page is reachable within 3–4 clicks from the homepage.
- **Hub-and-spoke / topic clusters** — a pillar page covering a broad topic, linked to supporting pages on subtopics, all interlinked. Signals topical authority.
- **Internal linking** — descriptive anchor text, contextual links from high-authority pages to new/important pages. Internal links pass equity and help Google understand site structure and topical relationships.
- **URL structure** — clean, keyword-relevant, short, lowercase, hyphen-separated, no parameters where possible. Avoid changing URLs on existing sites without 301 redirects.
- **Breadcrumbs** — aid UX and enable breadcrumb structured data.

3.4 Redirects & canonicals

- **301 (permanent)** — pass most link equity; use for permanent moves.
- **302 (temporary)** — use sparingly; does not consolidate equity.
- Avoid redirect chains >1 hop; fix them to direct 301s.
- **Canonical tags** (`rel="canonical"`) — tell Google the authoritative version of near-duplicate pages. Self-canonical every indexable page. Use for faceted navigation, print versions, parameter variants.
- **Hreflang** — for multi-language/multi-region sites; ensures the right language version is served.

3.5 Structured data (schema markup)

Structured data is code that describes your content to machines. It powers rich results (rich snippets), helps AI engines parse and cite content, and is now a foundational GEO signal ([Search Engine Land](#)).

Priority schema types to implement:

- Organization / LocalBusiness — business identity, NAP, hours, geo, service area.
- Article / BlogPosting / NewsArticle — content attribution, dates, author.
- Product + Offer + Review/AggregateRating — ecommerce.
- FAQ — question/answer pairs; eligible for rich results and AI extraction.
- HowTo — step-by-step instructions.
- Breadcrumb — navigation trail.
- Person (author) — supports E-E-A-T.
- Service / ServiceArea — service businesses.
- Speakable — identifies sections best for text-to-speech / voice.

Use [Schema.org](#) vocabulary, JSON-LD format (preferred over microdata/RDfA). Validate with Google's Rich Results Test and Schema Markup Validator. Implement via plugins (Rank Math, Yoast) on WordPress, native settings on Webflow, or hand-coded JSON-LD on custom builds.

3.6 Mobile, security, accessibility

- **Mobile-first indexing** — Google indexes the mobile version of a site as primary. Sites must be responsive and functional on mobile.
- **HTTPS** — mandatory; non-secure sites are penalized in trust. Free SSL via Let's Encrypt.
- **Accessibility (WCAG)** — alt text, semantic HTML, sufficient color contrast, keyboard navigation, descriptive link text. Not a direct ranking factor per se, but overlaps heavily with SEO and is increasingly legally expected. Accessible sites are also more parseable by AI engines.
- **Core Web Vitals** — covered above; a technical-quality signal and a tiebreaker among otherwise comparable results.

4. On-Page SEO

4.1 Keyword strategy & search intent

Search intent (the "why" behind a query) is the organizing principle. Four intents:

1. **Informational** — "how to fix a leaky faucet" (educate → capture top/mid funnel).
2. **Navigational** — "Acme Plumbing Calgary" (brand search → ensure brand page ranks).

3. **Commercial investigation** — "best plumber near me" / "plumber vs handyman" (compare → BOFU).
4. **Transactional** — "emergency plumber Calgary" / "book plumber online" (convert → bottom funnel).

Process: Map target keywords to intent, then to the page type that satisfies that intent. Don't try to rank a homepage for an informational long-tail — create the right page type for each intent.

4.2 Keyword research methodology

1. **Seed list** — services, products, locations, customer questions, competitor terms.
2. **Expand** — use Google Autocomplete, "People Also Ask," competitor analysis, and keyword tools (Ahrefs, Semrush, Google Keyword Planner).
3. **Filter** — by relevance, monthly search volume, keyword difficulty (KD), and CPC (commercial intent proxy).
4. **Cluster** — group keywords by intent and topic into clusters; each cluster becomes a page or pillar/spoke set.
5. **Prioritize** — balance difficulty vs. business value. Early on, target low-difficulty high-intent local terms; build up to harder terms as authority grows.

4.3 Topical authority / topic clusters

Build topical authority by comprehensively covering a subject. A pillar page covers the broad topic; spoke pages cover subtopics in depth; all interlink. This signals to Google (and AI engines) that the site is an authority on the subject — increasingly rewarded as semantic/topic authority ([OptimizeGEO](#)).

4.4 On-page elements checklist

Element	Best practice
Title tag	50–60 chars; primary keyword near front; include brand; unique per page; matches intent.
Meta description	150–160 chars; compelling, keyword-relevant, includes CTA/value. Not a ranking factor but drives CTR.
H1	One per page; includes primary keyword; matches title intent.
H2/H3	Logical hierarchy; use related/secondary keywords naturally.
URL slug	Short, keyword-relevant, lowercase, hyphen-separated.
Body content	Comprehensive, original, helpful, scannable (short paragraphs, lists, tables). Answer the query early (answer-first).
Images	Descriptive filenames, alt text, compressed, correct dimensions, modern formats.
Internal links	Contextual links to/from relevant pages with descriptive anchor text.
External links	Link out to authoritative sources to support claims (trust signal).
CTA	Clear, prominent call to action matching the page's intent.

4.5 Content briefs (the production unit)

Before writing any page, produce a content brief that specifies:

- Target primary + secondary keywords, search intent, and target SERP feature.
- Top-ranking competitor pages to analyze for depth, structure, topics covered.
- Questions to answer (from PAA, competitor FAQs, customer questions).
- Required E-E-A-T elements (author, original data/examples, sources).
- Required structure (headings, answer-first block, FAQ section, CTA).
- Internal/external linking targets.
- Word-count guidance based on competitor analysis (a floor, not a goal — depth for completeness, not length).

5. Content Engine & AI-Assisted Production

5.1 The content workflow

1. **Strategy** — identify topics via keyword research, customer questions, gap analysis vs. competitors.
2. **Brief** — produce a structured brief (above).
3. **Draft** — AI-assisted draft is acceptable; must be built on real expertise and brief requirements.
4. **Human expert review** — fact-check, add original examples/data, verify all claims and sources, inject first-hand experience. This step is non-negotiable for E-E-A-T and ranking in 2026.
5. **Optimize** — apply on-page elements, internal links, schema.
6. **Publish** — with proper metadata, dates, author attribution.
7. **Update cadence** — refresh cornerstone content quarterly with new data, examples, insights. AI engines weigh recency ([eMarketer](#)).

5.2 Quality bar (what makes content rank in 2026)

Per the March 2026 core update analysis, content that wins demonstrates ([DigitalApplied](#), [Yositeup](#)):

- **First-hand experience** — specific real examples a practitioner would recognize.
- **Original research/data** — proprietary numbers, tests, case studies.
- **Named, credentialed authors** — bylines, credentials, verifiable identity.
- **Proper sourcing** — claims traceable to authoritative sources (not "according to experts").
- **Information gain** — adds something new beyond what already exists online.
- **Depth and comprehensiveness** — covers the topic fully, not thin.

Content that loses: mass-produced, no original insight, vague citations, no real experience, templated/boilerplate.

5.3 Content production scale guidance

For retainers, a realistic content cadence:

- Local SMB retainer: 2–4 optimized pages/month.
- Mid-market: 8–15 articles/month.
- The 30% rule: if ~30%+ of a site's URLs are flagged unhelpful, sitewide demotion applies — so every published page must meet the quality bar; never publish filler to hit volume ([TheStacc](#)).

6. Off-Page SEO & Link Building

6.1 Why links still matter

Backlinks remain a top ranking factor — they're Google's primary signal of a page's authority and trustworthiness. But quality and relevance now dominate over raw quantity. Spammy, bought, or low-relevance links are actively discounted or penalized.

6.2 Google's prohibited link practices ([Google spam policies](#))

Do NOT do any of these for clients:

- Buying or selling links that pass PageRank (paid links must be `rel="sponsored"` / `rel="nofollow"`).
- Excessive link exchanges ("link to me and I'll link to you").
- Large-scale article marketing / guest posting with keyword-rich anchor text.
- Automated link building programs / link networks.
- Requiring a link as part of a Terms of Service or contract.
- Using widget links with keyword-rich anchors embedded across sites.

6.3 White-hat link building tactics (legitimate, durable)

Tactic	What it is	Best for
Digital PR	Newsworthy content/data/studies that journalists cite	Earning high-authority editorial links
Guest posting	Genuine expert contributions to relevant, authoritative sites (not at scale, not keyword-anchored)	Niche authority building
Local citations & links	Chamber of commerce, local business associations, community sponsorships, local press	Local SEO prominence
HARO / Connectively / Qwoted	Respond to journalist queries as an expert source	Earning editorial mentions/links

Tactic	What it is	Best for
Resource & linkable assets	Original data, tools, free calculators, comprehensive guides	Natural link attraction
Unlinked brand mentions	Find mentions of the client's brand without a link; request a link	Reclaiming earned authority
Broken link building	Find broken outbound links on relevant sites; suggest your content as a replacement	Niche, context-relevant links
Partnerships & testimonials	Provide testimonials to vendors/suppliers you genuinely use	Earn legitimate links
Industry directories	High-quality, relevant, human-curated directories (avoid mass directory submission)	Niche relevance

6.4 The shift to mentions and entity authority

With AI search, the focus is shifting from pure backlinks to **brand mentions and entity authority across the web**. AI engines pull heavily from Reddit, YouTube, Wikipedia, and review sites ([eMarketer](#)). Tactics:

- Earn positive mentions on Reddit, LinkedIn, industry forums.
- Build presence on YouTube (AI engines cite video sources).
- Pursue editorial "best of" lists and curated comparisons.
- Maintain consistent brand entity facts across the web (name, what you do, who runs it).

6.5 Link metrics to evaluate quality

- **Domain Rating / Domain Authority (DR/DA)** — site-level authority proxy.
- **Referring domains** — unique linking domains matter more than total links.
- **Relevance** — a link from a topically relevant site is worth more than a random high-DR link.
- **Editorial placement** — links within editorial context beat footer/sitewide/author bio links.
- **Anchor text** — natural, varied, descriptive; avoid over-optimizing for exact-match keywords.

7. Local SEO

Local SEO is the highest-ROI service for most client types in this business's target market. The local pack (map results) is governed by a distinct algorithm.

7.1 Local ranking factors (Whitespark 2026 survey — industry estimates)

The following weighting is from the Whitespark Local Search Ranking Factors industry survey (reported by industry outlets), not Google's published algorithm. Google's own stated local pillars are simply **Relevance, Distance, and Prominence** ([Google](#)); the percentages below are survey-derived estimates of how practitioners perceive signal influence:

Signal group	Estimated share of ranking influence
Google Business Profile signals	~32%
On-page website signals	~19%
Review signals	~16%
Link signals	~15%
Behavioral signals (calls, directions, clicks)	~8–10%
Citation signals (NAP consistency)	~7%

([ClickRank](#), [MediaSearchGroup](#), [Flento](#))

7.2 Google Business Profile (GBP) optimization SOP

GBP carries ~32% of local ranking weight — it is the single most important local asset.

Optimization checklist:

- **Verify the profile** (mail, phone, email, or video verification). Unverified profiles cannot rank in the local pack ([MediaSearchGroup](#)).
- **Primary category** — the #1 ranking factor. Choose the most specific category that accurately describes the core business. Audit competitors' categories; if they use a more specific sub-category, match or beat it.
- **Additional categories** — add up to 4 secondary categories for legitimate services. Businesses using 4 additional categories average the highest map rankings.
- **Business name** — must match real-world signage exactly. **No keyword stuffing** (e.g., "Smith Calgary Plumbing Emergency Plumber") — violates policy and risks suspension.
- **NAP (Name, Address, Phone)** — must match exactly across GBP, website footer, schema, directories — down to abbreviation style and phone formatting.
- **Business description** — use up to 750 characters; include core services and city naturally; written for users.
- **Services & products sections** — fully populate with specific service names and descriptions (each service = a keyword signal).
- **Hours** — accurate and current; add special holiday hours proactively. The 2026 Whitespark survey flagged "business is open at time of search" as a top-tier factor — incorrect hours cost rankings during actual operating hours ([MediaSearchGroup](#)).
- **Photos** — upload real photos (exterior, interior, team, work) monthly; minimum 2 new/month. Stock photos underperform.

- **Google Posts** — publish regularly (2/week is a common target; posts are now schedulable in advance); each post: CTA + photo + 100–200 words. Regular posting signals an active business and supports engagement/freshness ([MediaSearchGroup](#)).
- **Q&A** — seed 8–15 common customer questions with direct answers (claim the section before spammers do).
- **Reviews** — systematize review requests after every job; target a 4.5+ star average with 20+ recent reviews; respond to every review within 24–72 hours. Review recency matters more than historical volume.
- **Service area** — set accurately; don't over-expand. ~40-mile radius is a reasonable starting point for service-area businesses.

7.3 Citations & NAP consistency

- Build citations on authoritative directories (Google, Bing Places, Apple Maps, Facebook, Yelp, industry-specific directories, and the top 10–15 local directories).
- NAP must be **identical everywhere** — same name, same address format, same phone format.
- Audit with BrightLocal or Whitespark; fix the top 10–15 inconsistencies first; don't obsess over hundreds of low-quality directories.
- For multi-location businesses, build a unique location/landing page per location with unique content and the location's own GBP.

7.4 Local landing pages

Build city/service-area landing pages for each service area. Each page must have **unique, substantive content** (not templated duplicate content with only the city swapped — that's doorway spam). Include: service description, service area, NAP, testimonials, FAQ, map, CTA.

7.5 Local link building

Chamber of commerce, local business associations, community sponsorships, local press coverage, partnerships with complementary local businesses. These drive both local pack prominence and organic local rankings.

8. AI Search Optimization (GEO / AEO)

This is the newest and fastest-growing service line. Generative Engine Optimization (GEO) is the practice of structuring content and digital presence so AI answer engines — ChatGPT, Perplexity, Google AI Overviews, Gemini, Claude, Copilot — cite and recommend the brand in synthesized answers ([Search Engine Land](#), [TechTimes](#)).

8.1 Key principle: GEO is additive to SEO, not a replacement

Google's official position (first published May 15, 2026): "optimizing for generative AI search is still SEO." Strong organic rankings remain a prerequisite for AI Overview and Gemini citations ([Google Search Central](#), [WeTheFlywheel](#)). Content that already ranks well tends to perform well in AI Overviews.

8.2 On-page GEO tactics (highest-leverage)

Per the Princeton GEO research (Aggarwal et al.) and 2026 best-practice synthesis ([MaximusLabs](#), [WeTheFlywheel](#)):

- **Answer-first blocks** — place a self-contained 40–80 word answer block near the top of each section/page that directly answers the primary query, phrased as a user would phrase it. Every section should stand alone since AI engines pull individual chunks.
- **Authoritative quotations** — include at least one cited quote from a recognized authority. The single highest-lift intervention in the GEO research.
- **Quantified statistics** — add 2–3 specific statistics with named sources. Quotations and concrete statistics produced the largest citation lift; fluency and keyword stuffing produced almost none.
- **Structure for extraction** — clear headings, short paragraphs, lists, tables, explicit Q&A pairs.
- **Information gain** — original data, proprietary research, unique analysis. Pure AI-synthesized content adds no new information and rarely gets cited.
- **E-E-A-T signals** — bylines, credentials, citations to primary sources, original data. AI engines cite sources that are "safe to cite."

8.3 Technical GEO

- **Unblock AI crawlers** — ensure robots.txt allows GPTBot, ClaudeBot, PerplexityBot, Google-Extended (unless there's a strategic reason to block).
- **Schema markup** — Article, FAQ, HowTo, Organization, Breadcrumb, Speakable help AI engines parse and attribute content.
- **Expose facet metadata in text and FAQs** — make facts machine-readable.
- **Keep docs in subdirectories, not subdomains** (concentrates authority).
- **Maintain fresh dateModified timestamps** — AI engines weigh recency.
- **llms.txt file** — optional; some practitioners add it to guide AI systems on how to interpret the site. Google has said you can ignore "llms.txt" and inauthentic-mention tactics ([Google](#)) — treat as optional/experimental, not core.

8.4 Off-page / entity GEO

- **Third-party platform presence** — AI engines cite Reddit, YouTube, Wikipedia heavily. Build presence where your target engine cites most.
- **Earn editorial mentions** — digital PR, "best of" lists, curated comparisons, news coverage. These raise citation odds more than backlinks alone.
- **Entity consistency** — unified brand facts (name, what you do, founders, locations) across the website, knowledge panel, Wikipedia, Crunchbase, social profiles.

8.5 GEO measurement

Track metrics that actually reflect AI visibility — not impressions/pageviews:

- **Citation frequency** — how often AI platforms mention the brand for relevant queries.
- **Share of voice** — brand mention rate vs. competitors across a consistent query set.
- **AI-referred traffic** — GA4 attribution of visits/conversions from AI sources.
- **Sentiment** — whether AI mentions are accurate and positive.

Method: query ChatGPT, Perplexity, Gemini, and AI Overviews with prompts real customers would use; log which brands appear and which sources get cited; track over time ([eMarketer](#)).

8.6 GEO budget allocation framework

One recommended framework: 40% core SEO, 25% digital PR, 20% data & reporting, 10% training, 5% experimentation ([Search Engine Land](#)).

9. Website Creation

The website is the asset and the foundation of every SEO engagement. Building it right from the start saves months of remediation.

9.1 The website build process (SOP)

1. **Discovery & strategy** — business goals, target customers, services/products, competitors, brand, required functionality, integrations (CRM, booking, payments), content inventory. Output: sitemap + wireframes + functional spec.
2. **Information architecture** — logical page hierarchy, URL structure, navigation, internal linking plan.
3. **Design** — brand-aligned, conversion-focused, mobile-first, accessible, fast-by-design. Avoid heavy templates/bloat.
4. **Development** — build on chosen stack; semantic HTML; optimized images; minimal, deferred JS; schema; forms; analytics; security.
5. **Content** — write/assemble all page content per content briefs (above). Never launch with Lorem Ipsum or "coming soon."
6. **QA & pre-launch checklist** — see Website Launch Checklist (section 14).

7. **Launch** — point DNS, set up redirects from old site (if migration), submit sitemap to Search Console & Bing Webmaster, verify analytics.

8. **Post-launch** — monitor rankings/indexing/CWV for 30 days; fix issues; begin SEO retainer.

9.2 Platform/stack comparison (2026)

Factor	WordPress	Webflow	Shopify
Best for	Service businesses, local SEO, publishers, custom sites, content programs	Design-led marketing sites, portfolios, brands prioritizing design	Product-first ecommerce stores
Monthly platform cost (2026)	Hosting \$10–\$50/mo (managed \$15–\$50)	\$14–\$49/mo site plans; \$29–\$212/mo ecommerce	\$39–\$399/mo (Basic/Shopify/Advanced)
SEO control	Very High (full code + plugins)	Very High (clean semantic code, native SEO)	High (solid native, some URL structure limits)
Core Web Vitals out of box	Variable, plugin-dependent	Strong, clean code + global CDN	Good, theme-dependent
Schema	Full via plugins (Rank Math/Yoast)	Manual or embed	Product schema built in
Main trade-off	More maintenance/technical responsibility	Higher upfront if specialist needed; CMS item limits	Transaction fees if not on Shopify Payments; app costs at scale

([DreemWebsites](#), [WebHausCo](#), [TopDevs](#))

Recommendation by client type:

- **Local service businesses (trades, clinics, legal, professional services):** WordPress with Rank Math or Yoast. Maximum SEO control, strongest content/blog capability, lowest ongoing platform cost. This is the default choice for the target market.
- **Design-led marketing/brand sites, agencies, portfolios:** Webflow. Best-in-class design, strong native SEO, zero-maintenance hosting, fast out of box. Good when the client values design precision over content scalability.
- **Ecommerce / online stores:** Shopify. Purpose-built, reliable, scales. Accept its URL structure limits (/products/, /collections/). Use Shopify Payments to avoid 0.5–2% transaction fees.

9.3 WordPress specifics for SEO

- **SEO plugin:** Rank Math (preferred — more features on free tier) or Yoast (most established). Configure titles/meta, schema, sitemaps, social.
- **Hosting:** Use managed WordPress hosting (WP Engine, Kinsta, or quality Canadian host) — never cheap shared hosting for business sites. Hosting is the single most important speed investment.

- **Performance plugin:** WP Rocket (caching) + image optimization (ShortPixel/Imagify) + CDN (Cloudflare).
- **Security:** Wordfence or Sucuri; keep core/plugins/themes updated; strong admin passwords; 2FA; limit login attempts.
- **Themes:** Lightweight, fast, well-coded (GeneratePress, Kadence, Astra). Avoid bloated page-builder-heavy themes.
- **Maintenance:** Budget \$50–\$150/month per site for ongoing maintenance (updates, backups, monitoring, security).

9.4 Conversion optimization (CRO) essentials

Every site built should be conversion-focused, not just traffic-focused:

- **Clear value proposition** above the fold – what you do, for whom, why choose you.
- **Strong, repeated CTAs** – phone number (click-to-call on mobile), contact form, booking, "get a quote." Place CTAs throughout, not just once.
- **Trust signals** – reviews/testimonials, certifications, accreditations, guarantees, case studies, photos of real work/team.
- **Click-to-call & click-to-email** – for mobile users especially.
- **Lead capture forms** – short, frictionless; only essential fields.
- **Call tracking** – use tracking numbers (with proper schema ContactPoint and dynamic number insertion) to attribute calls/leads to SEO.
- **Fast loading** – every second of delay reduces conversions; CWV directly impacts conversion.

9.5 Analytics, tracking & integrations

Every site must launch with:

- **Google Analytics 4 (GA4)** – configured with key events (form submissions, calls, clicks-to-call, purchases).
- **Google Search Console** – verified, sitemap submitted, monitoring set up.
- **Bing Webmaster Tools** – often overlooked; free, captures ~10–15% of search traffic.
- **Conversion tracking** – define what a "lead" is for each client (form, call, booking, purchase) and track it.
- **CRM integration** – capture leads into the client's CRM (HubSpot, GoHighLevel, etc.) for follow-up.
- **Heatmaps/session recording** (Hotjar, Clarity) – optional but valuable for CRO.

10. Business Operations: Pricing, Packages, Delivery

10.1 Pricing benchmarks (2026, USD; convert to CAD at ~1.35–1.40x)

Prices below are industry-reported as of August 2026 from agency surveys and vendor pricing pages. SEO and SaaS pricing changes frequently and sources conflict — treat as approximate ranges and re-verify before quoting.

SEO retainers (monthly):

Tier	Monthly range (USD)	Typical client	Scope
Local / single-location	\$500–\$1,500	Single-location local business	GBP, basic on-page, limited local links
Small-to-midsize business	\$1,500–\$5,000	Regional SMB	Technical SEO, content, on/off-page, reporting
Mid-market	\$3,000–\$7,500	Multi-location / regional	Broader keyword coverage, dedicated content, link building
Advanced	\$7,500–\$15,000	National brands, competitive verticals	Full-service, aggressive content/links, CRO
Enterprise	\$15,000–\$50,000+	Fortune 1000, multi-language	Multi-team, large-scale technical, digital PR

([DigitalApplied](#), [Webtonic](#), [TheStacc](#))

Other benchmarks:

- Average agency retainer globally: ~\$2,900–\$3,209/month; local-focused: ~\$1,557/month ([Webtonic](#)).
- Average hourly rate (agencies): ~\$134 worldwide / ~\$148 US ([Webtonic](#)).
- Standalone technical audit: \$3,000–\$10,000 ([Webtonic](#)).
- AI search/GEO add-on: ~\$900+/month on top of SEO retainer ([Webtonic](#), [SEOSherpa](#)).
- Most agencies require 6–12 month minimum contracts ([GetAira](#)).
- Retainers used by 78% of providers; hourly by 35%; project-based by 49% ([TheStacc](#)).

10.2 Suggested productized packages for this business (Calgary/local SMB focus)

Pricing in CAD (converted from USD benchmarks + Canadian market adjustment). Start slightly below established agencies to win early clients, then raise as the book fills.

Package	Price (CAD/mo)	Target client	Deliverables
Starter Local SEO	\$750–\$1,200	Single-location trades/clinics	GBP optimization + management, NAP cleanup (top 10 dirs), 2 service/local pages per month, monthly report

Package	Price (CAD/mo)	Target client	Deliverables
Growth SEO	\$1,500–\$2,500	Established local/regional SMB	Above + technical SEO audit + fixes, 4–8 content pages/month, internal linking, basic link building, GA4 + rank tracking
Authority SEO	\$3,000–\$5,000	Multi-location / competitive niche	Above + aggressive content (8–12/mo), digital PR/link building, CRO, GEO/AI visibility monitoring, quarterly strategy
Website Build (one-time)	\$2,500–\$8,000+	New/redesign	Discovery, design, dev, content, SEO setup, launch, 30-day support
Technical SEO Audit (one-time)	\$500–\$2,000	Lead gen / diagnostic	Full audit + prioritized action plan + walkthrough call
GEO/AI-Visibility Add-on	\$300–\$1,000	Existing retainer clients	AI citation monitoring, answer-engine optimization, schema, entity consistency

Pricing principles:

- Never compete on price alone against commodity/offshore providers (\$200–\$800/mo deliver little value). Compete on results, expertise, and local presence.
- Minimum viable retainer for legitimate work: ~\$1,500/month. Below that, scope must be tightly limited.
- Always tie pricing to client value and outcomes (leads, revenue), not just hours/activity.
- Consider value-based pricing for high-value clients where ROI is clearly quantifiable.

10.3 Margins & unit economics

- **Tool costs:** A solo operator's core stack (Ahrefs or Semrush ~\$129–\$250/mo, plus rank tracker, GA4, Search Console) runs ~\$200–\$400/month total. One retainer at \$1,500/mo covers tooling many times over.
- **Content production:** Budget 20–40% of retainer revenue for content (writing, editing, expert review). Use AI-assisted drafting with human expert review to control cost while maintaining quality.
- **Labor:** As the business grows, outsource repeatable tasks (content drafting, citations, technical fixes) to vetted freelancers; keep strategy, client management, and QA in-house.
- **Target gross margin:** 60–70% on retainers after content/tool costs.

10.4 Client lifecycle & delivery operations

1. **Lead generation** — local networking, referrals, a strong website + SEO ranking for "SEO Calgary"/"web design Calgary," content marketing, Google Local Services Ads, partnerships.
2. **Discovery call** — understand goals, current state, budget, timeline. Qualify fit.
3. **Audit** — run technical + content + local + backlink audit. Produces the diagnostic + opportunity map.

4. **Proposal** — scope, deliverables, timeline, pricing, expected outcomes, terms. Use the Proposal Template (section 15).
5. **Onboarding** — collect access (Search Console, GA4, CMS, GBP, social), sign agreement, kickoff call, baseline metrics snapshot. Use the Onboarding Questionnaire (section 15).
6. **Execution** — month-by-month per the retainer scope, following SOPs.
7. **Monthly reporting** — rankings, traffic, leads/conversions, work completed, next month's plan. Use the Monthly Report Template (section 15).
8. **Quarterly business review** — deeper analysis, strategy refinement, upsell/renewal conversation.
9. **Renewal & expansion** — retain clients by delivering measurable results; expand scope (add GEO, more locations, CRO, paid search) as trust grows.

10.5 Sales & positioning

- **Niche down early.** Specialize (e.g., "SEO for home service businesses in Calgary") to build topical authority, referrals, and case studies faster than being a generalist.
- **Sell outcomes, not activities.** Clients care about calls, leads, revenue — not "we published 8 blog posts." Report on business metrics.
- **Set expectations honestly.** SEO takes 3–6 months to show meaningful movement, 6–12 months to compound. Never guarantee specific rankings (Google's own guidance; also unprofessional and risky).
- **Lead with a free or low-cost audit.** It demonstrates expertise, surfaces real opportunities, and creates urgency. Convert audits to retainers.
- **Case studies & testimonials** — the strongest sales asset. Document every win.

11. Tools Stack (2026)

11.1 SEO tools

Prices are published/industry-reported as of August 2026 and change frequently; verify on official pricing pages before quoting. Some sources conflict (e.g., Ahrefs switched to per-seat pricing in March 2026).

Tool	Purpose	Price (2026)	Notes
Ahrefs	Backlinks, keyword research, site audit, rank tracking	Starter \$29 / Lite \$129 / Standard \$249 / Advanced \$449 / Enterprise \$1,499 per month	Best backlink index; per-seat pricing since March 2026 (\$49–\$149/seat); Brand Radar (AI visibility) +\$199/mo
Semrush	All-in-one SEO/PPC/content, AI visibility	SEO \$139 / Starter \$199 / Pro+ \$299 / Advanced \$549 per month (annual saves ~17%)	Better all-rounder; AI toolkit bundled in Semrush One; seats \$45–\$100

Tool	Purpose	Price (2026)	Notes
Google Search Console	Indexing, performance, CWV, manual actions	Free	Essential; verify every client site
Bing Webmaster Tools	Bing indexing/performance	Free	Often overlooked; captures Bing traffic
Google Analytics 4	Traffic, conversions, user behavior	Free	Configure key events/conversions
PageSpeed Insights / Lighthouse	Core Web Vitals, performance	Free	Field + lab data
Schema Markup Validator / Rich Results Test	Validate structured data	Free	Google's tools
Rank Math / Yoast	WordPress on-page SEO, schema	Free / Premium ~\$79–\$99/yr	Rank Math preferred for free-tier features
Screaming Frog	Technical site crawl	Free (500 URLs) / £209/yr	Desktop crawler for deep audits
Surfer SEO / Clearscope	Content optimization (NLP terms, depth)	~\$69–\$189/mo	Helps match competitor depth
BrightLocal / Whitespark	Local SEO, citations, GBP tracking, rank tracking	~\$39–\$99/mo	Best for local/multi-location
Hotjar / Microsoft Clarity	Heatmaps, session recordings	Free tiers	CRO insights; Clarity is free
Google Tag Manager	Tag deployment, tracking	Free	Essential for analytics setup

([Ahrefs](#), [Konabayev](#), [SEOMator](#), [Hackceleration](#))

Starter stack recommendation (solo operator): Ahrefs Lite (\$129) OR Semrush SEO (\$139) + Google free tools (Search Console, GA4, PSI, GSC) + Screaming Frog free + BrightLocal (~\$39) + Rank Math free + Microsoft Clarity. Total ~\$170–\$210/month.

11.2 Website build tools

- **WordPress** (free software) + managed hosting (WP Engine/Kinsta, ~\$30–\$50/mo) + lightweight theme (GeneratePress/Kadence) + WP Rocket + ShortPixel + Cloudflare CDN.
- **Webflow** (\$14–\$49/mo site plans) for design-led builds.
- **Shopify** (\$39–\$399/mo) for ecommerce.
- **Design:** Figma (free/low-cost) for wireframes/mockups.
- **Development environment:** Local by Flywheel (free) for WordPress local dev.

11.3 Business operations tools

- **Project management:** Notion, ClickUp, or Asana (free tiers).
- **CRM:** HubSpot Free or GoHighLevel (for agencies doing lead-gen for clients).
- **Invoicing/payments:** Stripe + QuickBooks (Canada) / Wave (free Canadian accounting).
- **Communication:** Slack, Google Workspace.
- **Scheduling:** Calendly (free tier) for booking discovery calls.

12. Canada-Specific Compliance (critical for this business)

12.1 CASL (Canada's Anti-Spam Legislation)

CASL applies to any commercial electronic message (CEM) sent to an electronic address where the computer system is located in Canada — including emails, texts, and social DMs — regardless of where sender or recipient is located ([CRTC](#), [CBA](#)).

Three requirements for every CEM ([CRTC FAQ](#)):

1. **Consent** — express or implied. Express consent (opt-in) is the gold standard. No pre-checked boxes. Implied consent applies to existing business relationships (recent transaction) and publicly-published addresses (with stated/obvious consent).
2. **Identification** — clearly identify the sender and provide valid contact information.
3. **Unsubscribe mechanism** — simple, no-questions-asked, actioned within 10 business days.

Administrative penalties: Up to \$1 million (individual) / \$10 million (business) per violation ([Cyberimpact](#), [CBA](#)). (Note: CASL's proposed private right of action was repealed before coming into force; rely on CRTC administrative enforcement, not private lawsuits.)

Operational rules for this business:

- **Never buy email lists.** Address harvesting is prohibited under PIPEDA; using harvested lists risks CASL/PIPEDA violation ([OPC](#)).
- Only email people who gave express consent or where implied consent (existing business relationship) clearly applies.
- If doing cold outreach for clients, use legitimate channels (not unsolicited commercial email to strangers without consent). Outbound email prospecting to Canadians requires consent — cold email is largely non-compliant in Canada.
- Maintain consent records (who, when, how consent was obtained, what they were told).
- Include sender identification + working unsubscribe in every email.
- Use consent-compliant email platforms (Cyberimpact, Mailchimp, Brevo) that log consents and manage unsubscribes.

12.2 PIPEDA (Personal Information Protection and Electronic Documents Act)

PIPEDA governs collection, use, and disclosure of personal information (including email addresses) in commercial activities (OPC). Key principles to follow:

- **Accountability** — designate someone responsible for privacy compliance.
- **Identifying purposes** — tell people why you collect data, before or at collection.
- **Consent** — meaningful consent matching data sensitivity.
- **Limiting collection** — only collect what's necessary.
- **Limiting use/retention** — use only for stated purposes; retain only as long as needed.
- **Accuracy** — keep data accurate and current.
- **Safeguards** — protect data with appropriate security (physical, organizational, technological).
- **Openness** — make privacy policies readily available.
- **Individual access** — give access to/correction of personal data on request.

For client websites, always: publish a privacy policy, use secure forms (HTTPS), minimize data collected, obtain consent for marketing, enable access/correction, and protect stored data.

12.3 Other Canadian considerations

- **Privacy policy requirement** — every client site collecting any personal data (forms, analytics, cookies) needs a clear, accurate privacy policy and a cookie consent mechanism compliant with PIPEDA.
- **Bilingualism** — in some contexts (federally regulated businesses, Quebec under Bill 96), French language requirements may apply. For Quebec clients, consider French-language requirements.
- **Accessibility** — the Accessible Canada Act and provincial standards (e.g., AODA in Ontario) increasingly require accessible websites. Build to WCAG 2.1 AA as a baseline regardless of jurisdiction.
- **Taxes** — register for GST/HST once revenue exceeds the small-supplier threshold (\$30,000 over 4 consecutive quarters). Charge GST/HST on digital services. Alberta has no provincial sales tax (only 5% GST).
- **Business structure** — operate as a sole proprietor initially; incorporate (Alberta or federal) once revenue/liability justifies it. Consult an accountant.

13. Standard Operating Procedures (SOPs)

13.1 SEO Audit SOP

1. **Crawl the site** with Screaming Frog (full crawl) + Google's URL Inspection in Search Console.
2. **Indexation check** — confirm key pages are indexed in Search Console; identify pages not indexed and why.
3. **Technical audit** — Core Web Vitals (PageSpeed Insights), mobile usability, HTTPS, broken links (404s), redirect chains, canonical issues, sitemap/robots.txt health, structured data validation, hreflang (if multi-language).
4. **On-page audit** — title/meta, H1s, content quality/depth, keyword targeting, internal linking, thin/duplicate content.
5. **Content & keyword gap analysis** — vs. top competitors: what topics/keywords they rank for that the client doesn't.
6. **Backlink audit** — referring domains, toxic/spammy links, link velocity, competitor link profile comparison.
7. **Local audit** — GBP completeness/accuracy, NAP consistency across directories, review volume/rating, local pack visibility, local citations.
8. **AI visibility audit** — query AI engines with buyer prompts; note if/how the brand appears; identify cited competitors.
9. **Conversion audit** — CTAs, forms, call tracking, page speed impact on conversion.
10. **Output:** prioritized action plan (quick wins, medium-term, strategic) with expected impact + effort. Present on a walkthrough call.

13.2 Keyword Research SOP

1. Define business goals, services, target locations, and customer personas.
2. Build seed keyword list from services/products/locations/customer questions.
3. Expand via Google Autocomplete, "People Also Ask," competitor analysis (Ahrefs/Semrush).
4. Pull search volume, keyword difficulty, CPC, and SERP features.
5. Map each keyword to search intent (informational/navigational/commercial/transactional).
6. Cluster keywords by topic and intent into pillar/spoke groups.
7. Prioritize by (business value × achievable difficulty). Target low-diff high-intent terms first.
8. Map clusters to existing or new pages; build a content calendar.

13.3 Local SEO SOP (monthly)

1. **GBP management** — review performance (calls, directions, clicks); respond to all new reviews; publish 2+ posts; upload 2+ photos; check hours (especially pre-holiday); review Q&A.
2. **Reviews** — send review requests to recent customers; respond to all reviews within 24–72h.

3. **Citations** — monthly NAP consistency audit (BrightLocal/Whitespark); fix new inconsistencies.
4. **Local content** — publish/refresh location and service-area pages.
5. **Local links** — pursue one local link/mention per month (chamber, sponsorship, local press, partnership).
6. **Report** — local pack visibility, GBP calls/directions, review growth, citation health.

13.4 Website Build SOP

See section 9.1. Summary: Discovery → IA → Design → Development (semantic HTML, optimized images, minimal JS, schema, forms, analytics, security) → Content (all pages, no placeholders) → QA (pre-launch checklist) → Launch (DNS, redirects, sitemap submission, analytics verification) → Post-launch monitoring (30 days).

13.5 Monthly SEO Retainer SOP

1. **Review performance** — rankings, traffic, conversions vs. prior month and baseline.
2. **Technical maintenance** — monitor CWV, indexation, Search Console for errors/manual actions; fix issues.
3. **Content production** — publish the month's content per the content calendar (brief → AI-assisted draft → expert review → optimize → publish).
4. **On-page optimization** — refresh/expand existing pages; improve titles/meta/internal links.
5. **Link building** — execute the month's link building tactics (digital PR, guest posts, local links, unlinked mentions).
6. **Local SEO** — execute the local SOP (if applicable).
7. **GEO** — refresh cornerstone content; monitor AI citations.
8. **Report** — deliver the monthly report; set next month's plan.

13.6 Reporting SOP

1. Pull data from Search Console (impressions, clicks, CTR, avg position), GA4 (sessions, conversions, events), rank tracker (keyword positions), GBP (calls, directions, clicks, photos).
2. Compare to prior month and baseline (month 0).
3. Highlight wins (rankings gained, traffic growth, leads generated).
4. Be honest about flat/declining areas with explanation and plan.
5. List work completed this month and planned for next month.
6. Tie activity to business outcomes (leads, calls, revenue) — not just vanity metrics.
7. Deliver via the monthly report template + a short call or Loom video.

14. Checklists

14.1 Website Launch Checklist (pre-go-live)

Technical:

- ☐ HTTPS with valid SSL certificate
- ☐ All pages return 200 status (no 404s/500s on key URLs)
- ☐ 301 redirects set up from old URLs (if migration)
- ☐ robots.txt configured correctly (not blocking important pages; AI crawlers allowed)
- ☐ XML sitemap generated and submitted to Search Console + Bing
- ☐ Canonical tags on all indexable pages
- ☐ Structured data (Organization/LocalBusiness, Breadcrumb, Article, FAQ as relevant) validated
- ☐ Open Graph + Twitter Card tags for social sharing
- ☐ 404 page with helpful navigation
- ☐ No broken internal/external links
- ☐ No Lorem Ipsum / placeholder / "coming soon" content

Performance:

- ☐ Core Web Vitals pass (LCP $\leq 2.5s$, INP $\leq 200ms$, CLS ≤ 0.1) on key templates
- ☐ Images optimized (WebP/AVIF, correct dimensions, lazy-loaded except LCP)
- ☐ JS/CSS minified and deferred; critical CSS inlined
- ☐ CDN configured
- ☐ Caching configured (page + browser + object)

SEO:

- ☐ Title tags and meta descriptions on all pages (unique, optimized)
- ☐ H1 on every page (one per page)
- ☐ Heading hierarchy correct
- ☐ All pages have substantial, original, helpful content
- ☐ Internal linking implemented
- ☐ Image alt text on all images
- ☐ Schema markup implemented and validated
- ☐ GBP linked to website; NAP consistent across site footer + schema

Tracking & conversion:

- ☐ GA4 installed + key events/conversions configured
- ☐ Search Console + Bing Webmaster verified, sitemap submitted

- ☐ Conversion tracking (forms, calls, purchases) configured
- ☐ CRM integration tested (leads flow through)
- ☐ Call tracking number with proper schema (if used)
- ☐ Heatmap/session recording installed (optional)

Security & legal:

- ☐ Strong admin passwords + 2FA
- ☐ Security plugin/firewall configured (WordPress)
- ☐ Backups configured and tested (on + off-site)
- ☐ Privacy policy page published
- ☐ Cookie consent mechanism (PIPEDA-compliant)
- ☐ Terms of service (if applicable)
- ☐ Contact page with NAP, map, hours

Mobile & accessibility:

- ☐ Fully responsive; tested on iOS + Android, multiple screen sizes
- ☐ Tap targets adequately sized
- ☐ Color contrast meets WCAG AA
- ☐ Keyboard navigation works
- ☐ Screen reader tested on key pages

14.2 SEO Quality Checklist (before publishing any page)

- ☐ Targets a primary keyword with clear search intent
- ☐ Title tag (50–60 chars, keyword front, includes brand)
- ☐ Meta description (150–160 chars, compelling, CTA)
- ☐ One H1; logical H2/H3 hierarchy
- ☐ Answer-first block answering the primary query
- ☐ Comprehensive, original content (matches/beats competitor depth)
- ☐ First-hand experience / original data / examples included
- ☐ Named author with credentials; sources cited for claims
- ☐ Internal links to/from relevant pages
- ☐ External links to authoritative sources
- ☐ Images optimized with alt text
- ☐ Schema markup relevant to content type
- ☐ Clear CTA matching intent
- ☐ Mobile-friendly, passes CWV

14.3 "Definition of Done" for monthly SEO deliverable

- ☐ All planned content published and meeting the quality checklist
- ☐ All technical issues identified this month resolved or ticketed
- ☐ Link building targets for the month met
- ☐ Local SEO tasks (if applicable) completed
- ☐ Reports generated and delivered to client
- ☐ Next month's plan set and agreed

15. Client-Facing Templates

15.1 Audit Summary (deliverable structure)

[CLIENT] SEO Audit – [DATE]
Prepared by: [Your Business]

1. Executive Summary
 - Overall site health score
 - Top 3 quick wins
 - Top 3 strategic opportunities
 - Key risks
2. Technical Findings
 - Indexation status
 - Core Web Vitals (LCP/INP/CLS per key template)
 - Crawl errors, broken links, redirect issues
 - Mobile usability
 - Structured data gaps
3. On-Page & Content Findings
 - Title/meta issues
 - Content quality/gaps
 - Keyword opportunities (with volume/difficulty)
 - Competitor content gap
4. Local SEO Findings (if applicable)
 - GBP completeness score
 - NAP consistency
 - Review status
 - Local pack visibility
5. Backlink Profile
 - Referring domains
 - Toxic/spammy links
 - Competitor comparison
6. AI Visibility (GEO)
 - Current citation status across AI engines
 - Cited competitors
 - Opportunities

7. Prioritized Action Plan
 - Quick wins (0-30 days)
 - Medium-term (1-3 months)
 - Strategic (3-12 months)
 - Expected impact + effort per item

15.2 Proposal Template

[CLIENT] – SEO & Website Services Proposal

Date: [DATE] | Valid for: 30 days

1. Objectives
 - [Business goals: e.g., increase qualified leads from organic search by X%]
2. Scope of Services
 - [Website build / SEO retainer / audit – detailed deliverables]
3. Approach & Methodology
 - [Brief description of how you'll work: audit → strategy → execution → reporting]
4. Deliverables & Timeline
 - [Milestones with dates]
5. Investment
 - [Itemized pricing; one-time + monthly]
 - [Contract term: e.g., 6-month initial, month-to-month after]
6. Expected Outcomes
 - [Realistic expectations; what success looks like; timeline]
 - Note: SEO is a compounding investment; meaningful results typically take 3-6 months
7. What's Not Included (exclusions)
 - [Paid ads, certain content, etc.]
8. Terms
 - Payment schedule, late fees, cancellation terms
 - Client responsibilities (access, approvals, content input)
 - Ownership of work
9. Next Steps
 - Sign agreement → onboard → kickoff

15.3 Onboarding Questionnaire

Business name:

Website URL:

Business address (NAP – must match Google Business Profile):

Primary services/products:

Target locations / service area:

Target customers (who, demographics, pain points):

Top competitors (3-5):

Current marketing channels (paid ads, social, email):

Current monthly leads/customers from web:
Goals for next 6-12 months:
Previous SEO/web work? What was done? By whom?
Access needed:
- Google Search Console (owner/user)
- Google Analytics 4 (admin)
- CMS login (WordPress/Webflow/Shopify admin)
- Google Business Profile (manager)
- Social media (if relevant)
- CRM
- Hosting/Domain registrar
Brand assets (logo, colors, fonts, brand guidelines):
Preferred contact method & frequency:

15.4 Monthly Report Template

[CLIENT] SEO Report – [MONTH YEAR]

1. Executive Summary
 - Headline metric (e.g., +18% organic leads MoM)
 - Key wins, any concerns
2. Business Outcomes (the metrics that matter)
 - Organic sessions: [n] (▲/▼ x% vs. prior month; ▲/▼ x% vs. baseline)
 - Conversions/leads: [n] (▲/▼ x%)
 - Calls from web/GBP: [n]
 - Keyword rankings: [n] in top 3 / top 10 / top 100
 - GBP calls/directions/clicks: [n]
 - Revenue attributed (if measurable): [n]
3. Work Completed This Month
 - Technical fixes
 - Content published (with URLs)
 - Link building results (links earned)
 - Local SEO actions
 - GEO/AI actions
4. Rankings Movement
 - Keywords gained / lost / held
 - Notable movement (up and down)
5. Next Month's Plan
 - Priorities and planned deliverables
6. Notes & Recommendations

15.5 Guarantee / Risk Language

Never guarantee specific rankings — Google explicitly warns against it, and it's unprofessional.
Instead:

"We do not guarantee specific rankings or traffic, as search results are determined by Google's algorithms outside any provider's control. What we guarantee is professional execution of proven SEO best practices, transparent reporting, regular communication, and continuous optimization based on data. SEO is a compounding investment; meaningful results typically take 3–6 months and continue to grow over time. If you're not seeing progress within 6 months, we'll work with you to adjust strategy — or you can exit the retainer."

16. 30/60/90-Day Launch Plan (for the business itself)

Days 1–30: Foundation

- Incorporate/register the business; set up accounting (GST registration when threshold nears).
- Build your own agency website (eat your own cooking — it's your best sales asset and case study).
- Set up the tool stack (Ahrefs or Semrush, free Google tools, Screaming Frog, BrightLocal, Rank Math).
- Define service packages and pricing (section 10.2).
- Create proposal, audit, onboarding, and report templates.
- Set up CRM, project management, invoicing (Stripe + Wave/QuickBooks).
- Begin ranking your own site for "SEO Calgary" / "web design Calgary" / niche terms.
- List your GBP and optimize it fully (practicing what you preach).

Days 31–60: First Clients

- Do 5–10 free or low-cost audits for target prospects (local service businesses).
- Network locally (chambers, BNI, industry associations); offer to speak at local business events.
- Convert 2–3 audits into Starter/Growth retainers + 1–2 website builds.
- Document every engagement as a future case study (with permission).
- Refine SOPs based on real delivery.

Days 61–90: Systematize & Scale

- Standardize delivery; document SOPs; build a repeatable content + link building engine.
- Hire first contractor (content writer / VA) as retainer volume grows.
- Publish case studies; collect testimonials; add to website.
- Raise pricing as the book fills; add the GEO/AI add-on as a differentiator.
- Begin outbound + partnerships; set up referral incentives.
- Set quarterly goals (retainers, revenue, client count) and review monthly.

17. AI Agent Operating Rules

Paste this section as standing instructions for the AI agent when operating this business.

When operating the SEO & website-creation business described above, follow these rules:

1. **Principles first.** Every action must serve the client's business outcomes (leads, calls, revenue), not vanity metrics. Always optimize for the end customer of the client.
2. **Never violate Google's spam policies.** No buying links, no mass-produced AI content to manipulate rankings, no keyword stuffing, no cloaking, no doorway pages, no expired domain abuse, no scraped content. When unsure, consult [Google's spam policies](#).
3. **AI-assisted content, not AI-generated content.** AI may draft; a human expert must review, fact-check, add original insight/examples, and verify every claim. Never publish unreviewed AI output. Every page must add information gain — original data, first-hand experience, or expert perspective.
4. **E-E-A-T on every page.** Named authors with credentials, sourced claims, original data/examples, transparent business info, accurate facts.
5. **Technical foundation first.** Before content or links, ensure the site is crawlable, indexable, fast (Core Web Vitals: LCP ≤2.5s, INP ≤200ms, CLS ≤0.1), secure (HTTPS), and mobile-friendly.
6. **Answer-first content.** Lead with a direct answer to the primary query; structure for extraction (clear headings, short paragraphs, lists, tables, FAQ).
7. **GEO is part of SEO.** Unblock AI crawlers; deploy schema; maintain freshness; earn third-party mentions; track AI citation visibility. Do not abandon proven SEO to chase unproven GEO hacks.
8. **Local SEO for local clients.** GBP is the #1 asset (~32% of local ranking). Optimize it fully, post 2x/week, systematize reviews, keep NAP consistent everywhere.
9. **Honest expectations.** SEO takes 3–6 months for meaningful results, 6–12 to compound. Never guarantee specific rankings. Report on business outcomes.
10. **Comply with Canadian law.** CASL (consent, identification, unsubscribe; no bought lists; no cold email without consent) and PIPEDA (privacy, data minimization, safeguards). Include privacy policies and cookie consent on all client sites.
11. **Document everything.** Use SOPs, checklists, and templates. Maintain audit trails for consent, changes, and reporting.
12. **Re-verify time-sensitive facts.** Google policies, Core Web Vitals thresholds, tool pricing, and agency benchmarks change. Re-verify anything older than 6 months before quoting to a client.
13. **Continuous improvement.** Track results, learn from every engagement, refine SOPs, invest in better tools/content as the business grows. Treat the agency's own website and SEO as the flagship case study.

18. Sources (key references)

- [Google Search Central — Creating helpful content, Spam policies, Core Web Vitals, AI optimization guide](#)
- [Google Business Profile ranking help](#)
- [DigitalApplied — March 2026 Core Update and Core Web Vitals benchmarks 2026](#)
- [Search Engine Land — GEO 2026 guide](#)
- [eMarketer — GEO/AEO FAQ](#)
- [TheStacc — Google AI content policy 2026](#)
- [Layer3Labs — Google AI content guidelines](#)
- [OuterBox — SEO pricing 2026](#), [Webtonic — SEO prices](#), [DigitalApplied — SEO pricing](#), [TheStacc — pricing models](#), [SEOSherpa](#), [GetAira](#)
- [Ahrefs pricing](#), [Konabayev — SEO tool pricing 2026](#), [SEOMator — Semrush vs Ahrefs](#)
- [ClickRank — Local SEO ranking factors](#), [MediaSearchGroup — local SEO 2026](#), [Flento](#)
- [DreemWebsites — WordPress vs Shopify vs Webflow](#), [WebHausCo](#), [TopDevs](#)
- [CRTC — CASL guide and FAQ](#), [OPC — CASL guidance](#), [Cyberimpact — CASL/PIPEDA](#), [CBA](#)

End of operating manual. This document is a living reference — update it as Google policies, tool pricing, and best practices evolve. Re-verify all time-sensitive facts before quoting to clients.